

97*
PEOPLE KILLED
and 533 injured by leopards in Uttarakhand in the last five years

59*
DEATHS
and 36 injuries were caused by tigers

371*
PEOPLE KILLED
and 2,015 injured by various wild animals. The death toll was over 900 in the last 25 years

**Figures for 2021-2025; source: Uttarakhand Forest Department*



more than 900 people have been killed by various wild animals across the state. Of these, as many as 371 deaths, along with 2,015 injuries, have been reported in the past five years alone.

This year, too, has begun on an ominous note for the state. Three women cutting grass were attacked in February in Haldwani's Fatehpur range in Nainital district; one was dragged nearly three kilometres away. In January, in Ramnagar, a gateway to the famed Corbett

"Uttarakhand has seen a significant rise in the numbers of wild animals over the years. Also, a large share of our population lives close to forests. With such proximity, negative interactions are bound to occur"

DR VIVEK PANDEY, *Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests (Wildlife), Uttarakhand*

EARLY IN FEBRUARY THIS YEAR, A LEOPARD SNATCHED FIVE-YEAR-OLD DAKSH BISHT from the courtyard of his home in Sindravani village of mountainous Rudraprayag district. "His mother started screaming," recalls Vinod Rana, husband of the village pradhan. "We ran towards the forest. By then, the sun had set and we were searching with the flashlights of our mobile phones. Forest teams reached around 8 or 9 pm. The child's mauled body was found around 11 pm, roughly a kilometre away. This was the first killing here in decades." The leopard was later trapped, but not before fear and unease took firm hold over the entire village.

Across Uttarakhand, the buffer between forest and habitation seems to be fast disappearing. Leopards have been found roaming inside residential colonies in the towns of Nainital, Haldwani and parts of Dehradun. CCTV clips of big cats walking past parked cars circulate widely.

As big cats stray from forest boundaries, human-animal conflict is bound to escalate. Leopards were responsible for 97 deaths and 533 injuries between 2021 and 2025. Tigers follow with 59 deaths—with a sharp rise evident from 2022 onward—along with 36 injuries during the same period (see *Big Cat Attacks*). Over the past 25 years, National Park and near the edge of the Terai forest, a young man was found killed after a tiger reportedly dragged him into the forest. Two more deaths have been reported in the area in the past three months. Almora and the hill blocks of Nainital district—Bhimtal, Dhari and Okhalkanda—also saw women collecting fodder fall prey to big cats between December and January. "Here," says Harish Paneru of Dalkanya village in Okhalkanda block, "we are living in a COVID-like lockdown. Domesticated animals are attacked. Doors shut before dusk. Children are afraid to walk to school. Farmers are scared to tend their fields alone."

BEHIND THE SURGE

The rise in encounters is by no means accidental. Big cat numbers have been seeing a steady rise. According to government data, leopard numbers rose from 2,092 in 2003 to 2,927 in 2023, an increase of nearly 40 per